

The Researcher's Herald

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Finding Your Voice (and Your Visibility)

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Abstract:

In the second edition of the newsletter, I will be sharing my past failures and struggles in public speaking, especially during conferences where our voice becomes the difference-maker between leaving a good impression on your audience or making them feel disinterested. From there, I will share some tips and advice given to me since my Ph.D. candidature which will hopefully serve us well moving ahead.

It was in July 2022 when I delivered my first semi-plenary talk at the International Conference on Modern Practice in Stress and Vibration Analysis (MPSVA 2022), organised by the UK Institute of Physics Applied Mechanics Group. All was seemingly well, that is until the dreaded "Questions and Answers" (Q&A) segment.

Within a matter of seconds, what was seemingly a moment of honour, turned into a nightmare. I was nervous and struggled through the Q&A. Members of the audience could see that, and some were less forgiving. When all is said and done, I walked away feeling I had not done any justice to the opportunity. That experience highlighted a gap I could no longer ignore: Public speaking.

You see, when we speak up, we don't just share ideas – we create new connections just like how it works in the corporate world. During conferences, senior professors and fellow early-career researchers have reached out to connect, exchange ideas, and collaborate. And with each opportunity, you learn more than any textbook could teach.

This lays the foundation for science communication, which to me is a non-negotiable role of a researcher beyond just making groundbreaking discoveries. There is a distinct difference between talking and communicating:

- **Talking:**

The act of verbalising thoughts and opinions to an individual or a group of audience; while

- **Communicating:**

The ability of breaking down complex concepts to layman terms, and explaining them logically and coherently such that the general audience (especially those outside your field) is able to understand the concept the same way as you do – i.e., the transmission of idea(s) and bringing about understanding.

In academia (and beyond), we need to communicate to bring visibility to our work and ourselves. For this reason, your voice is your visibility – your greatest marketing tool for your research.

With that in mind, here are four suggestions that can be considered to work on and improve our public speaking and communication skills:

- **Study great speakers:**

1. When attending conferences or seminars, do take note of speakers who have captured your interest and attention. Observe the words they used to describe their works, how did they verbalise their points across, and how did they design their powerpoint slides.
2. Watch Youtube videos on science communication and public speaking – e.g., TedTalks, Veritasium, SmarterEveryDay, etc.
3. Check out science communication pages on Instagram which provides good examples on how we visualise scientific explanations, keep things simple, and make them sound fun – e.g., @tomrocksmaths, @justkeepthinkingsg, etc.

- **Practice in low-stakes settings:**

Start off with getting your friends together as a small group, especially those from outside your field, and practice speaking and communicating with them on your research. It provides a safe space for feedbacks and a good litmus test to see how effective we have communicated out content to our audience. One may also consider volunteering during your Supervisor group meetings to practice.

Learning is most effective when we actually do it – by getting our hands dirty!

- **Develop your own authentic style:**

As we progressively learn and try to adopt the various good practices seen from the positive examples, it is easy to lose authenticity as we try to force ourselves to fit. This never works out well, as one loses his/her authenticity. This is perhaps one of the last things one hopes for in public speaking and science communication – we want to it to come from YOU!

Do take time to occasionally pause, reflect, and understand what works for you and what does not. The good examples and practices serve as a guide, and not the hard rule. Keep practicing and over time, you will develop a style that is uniquely you!

- **Focus on clarity for non-specialists:**

At a talk by Nobel Laureate Professor Sir Richard Roberts, he spoke of the “Grandmother Test” where you try to explain what you do to your Grandmother. And if she understands what you are saying, you passed the test! :)

This is perhaps the biggest challenge for researchers, how do we explain and simplify concepts into layman terms, such that those outside our field are able to understand the concepts the way we do? This comes with the detailed understanding of our work, which is acquired over time through the course of our research journey, as well as practice (i.e., see previous point on practicing in low-stakes settings). The focus is essentially on being able to break down complex concepts into simpler, and understandable terms and illustrations.

In summary, to all fellow early-career researchers:

1. Speak up.
2. Start small.
3. Be authentic.

Because every voice deserves to be heard (and seen):
Voice = Visibility.

You got this! :)

P.S. Should you have any further points to add to this, please do not hesitate to contact me and share what you have learnt from your experience!